FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

GAME DAY NERVES

Butterflies are normal. Here's how to help them fly in formation.

THE QUICK VERSION

> Nearly every player gets nervous before a big game, a final or a trial, including the pros. Nerves aren't a sign that something is wrong. They're a sign that your child cares. Your job isn't to make the nerves disappear, it's to help your child feel ready for them.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Before a game, the body releases adrenaline: a racing heart, a funny tummy, sweaty hands. That same energy can make a player sharper and faster. It only becomes a problem when a child reads those feelings as "I'm going to play badly." Helping them reframe nerves as "my body is getting ready" can change everything.

A CALM GAME DAY ROUTINE

1

THE NIGHT BEFORE

Pack the bag together, lay out the kit, and keep the evening relaxed. Screens off early for a good sleep.

2

GAME MORNING

A familiar breakfast, plenty of water and a normal routine. Keep chat light and avoid big pep talks.

3

JUST BEFORE KICK-OFF

A simple cue: three slow breaths, a high five and "Have fun, I love watching you."

WHAT NERVES CAN LOOK LIKE

BODY

- Tummy aches or not wanting breakfast
- Needing the toilet a lot
- Yawning or fidgeting

MOOD

- Quiet, snappy or clingy
- Lots of "what if" questions
- Saying they don't want to go

HELPS

- Breathing slowly, in for 4, out for 6
- Focusing on one simple job
- Music or a familiar routine

TRY THIS

1 Name it, normalise it
"Feeling nervous means you care. Lots of players feel exactly the same."

2 Reframe the feeling
Swap "I'm scared" for "I'm excited." The body feels almost the same either way.

3 Give them one job
"Win your first tackle" or "Talk to your teammates." A clear task calms a busy mind.

4 Practise breathing together
Breathe in for four, out for six. Practise at home so it's easy on game day.

5 Keep your own nerves in check
Kids pick up on our energy. Stay relaxed, even if you're nervous too.

6 Know when it's more
If worry is stopping them from enjoying sport or life, talk to your GP or school counsellor.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"It's normal to feel nervous. It means you care."	~~"There's nothing to be nervous about."~~
"Just focus on your first touch."	~~"This is the biggest game of the season."~~
"Have fun, I love watching you."	~~"Don't let us down today."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] We have a simple, calm game day routine
- [ ] My child knows nerves are normal
- [ ] We've practised a breathing technique together
- [ ] I keep my own nerves to myself on game day

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

"Almost every big game starts with butterflies in the dressing room. The best players don't have fewer nerves. They've just learned what to do with them.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM